

ATS2640 — Flashcards

Quick-review cards, grouped by topic. Cover the right column, say the answer aloud, then check. Start at the top — the Level-0 cards are the master key everything else hangs off.

Level 0 — The master key (learn these cold)

Prompt	Answer
What is ethics, in this unit?	Reasoned argument about what's right and wrong to do — backed by reasons, not just feelings or taste.
Descriptive vs normative?	Descriptive = how things <i>are</i> ("most states have armies"); normative = how things <i>ought</i> to be. This unit is normative.
What should your oral answers be?	Mini-arguments (reasons → a conclusion), not bare opinions.
Why reject relativism?	If morality were "just opinion" you couldn't call a massacre wrong — only say you dislike it. We <i>can</i> call it wrong, so relativism is set aside.
THE MASTER KEY — the two theories behind nearly everything?	Consequentialism (only outcomes matter) vs deontology/absolutism (some acts are wrong in themselves whatever the outcome).
Define consequentialism.	An act is right if it produces the best overall outcome (most good, least suffering). <i>"Drop the bomb if it ends the war and saves more lives."</i>
Define deontology (absolutism).	Some acts are wrong in themselves, whatever the result — duties/rights you must not violate even for good outcomes. <i>"Never deliberately kill an innocent, even to win."</i>
The clash in one example?	Ending a war by deliberately bombing a city of innocents: the consequentialist may say yes (fewer deaths), the deontologist says no (murder is wrong in itself).
Tool — intention vs foresight?	<i>Intending</i> a harm (it's your aim or means) vs merely <i>foreseeing</i> it as a side-effect. Deontologists think this matters enormously.
Tool — doing vs allowing?	Killing someone vs letting them die; often treated as morally different even at the same outcome.
Tool — rights & duties?	A right (e.g. not to be killed) creates a duty in others, and can "trump" even very good outcomes.
Tool — moral status / respect?	Persons have a dignity; how you treat someone can fail to respect it even if the outcome is "fine." (Becomes Sparrow's robots argument.)

The big picture — the question & three traditions

Prompt	Answer
The core question of the unit?	Is war ever morally justified — and if so, what limits apply to how it's fought?
Combatant vs non-combatant?	Combatant = fights / part of the war machine; non-combatant = doesn't. This line is the most important distinction in the unit.
Define aggression.	Using force against another state's sovereignty or territory — the standard wrong that starts an unjust war.
Define sovereignty.	A state's right to run its own affairs free from outside force.
The three traditions?	Realism (morality doesn't apply to war), pacifism (war is never justified), just war theory (sometimes, if strict criteria are met).
Realism + its reason (who)?	Morality doesn't really apply to war (Morgenthau, Bacevich); in an anarchic world states must pursue survival, and one that fights morally while enemies don't will lose.
Pacifism + its reason (who)?	War is never justified (Tolstoy) — either killing is always wrong (absolutist) or the costs always outweigh the gains (contingent).
Anscombe on pacifism?	She <i>attacks</i> it: calling all killing "murder" erases the combatant/innocent line, which can make atrocity easier. She's a just-war Catholic, not a pacifist.
Just war theory in one line?	War is sometimes justified if strict conditions are met — blending deontological limits (never target innocents) with consequentialist checks (proportionality).
Who rebuts <i>both</i> realism and pacifism?	Orend — the just-war answer to both: morality <i>does</i> apply to war, and war <i>can</i> sometimes be justified.

Just War Theory — the two halves

Prompt	Answer
JWT's two independent halves?	Jus ad bellum = justice of <i>going to</i> war; jus in bello = justice <i>in</i> fighting. Judged separately.
Why independent?	A war can be just to start but fought with atrocities, or unjust to start but fought cleanly. Confusing them is a classic error.
Example — just to start, fought unjustly?	A justified self-defence that then deliberately bombs enemy civilians.
Example — unjust to start, fought cleanly?	An aggressive invasion whose soldiers still target only combatants and spare civilians.
Jus post bellum?	Justice <i>after</i> war (settlements, reconstruction, accountability). A minor third part.

The criteria

Prompt	Answer
Jus ad bellum criteria?	Just cause · legitimate authority · right intention · proportionality · last resort · reasonable prospect of success.
Just cause?	A genuine wrong to respond to — usually self-defence against aggression.
Legitimate authority?	Declared by a proper public authority, not a private group.
Right intention?	Actually aiming at the just cause, not using it as cover (e.g. seizing resources).
Last resort?	Peaceful options tried or genuinely exhausted first.
Reasonable prospect of success?	Don't wage hopeless slaughter with no chance of achieving the just cause.
Jus in bello criteria?	Distinction · proportionality · no mala in se · necessity.
Distinction?	Only target combatants; never deliberately target non-combatants. The big one.
In bello proportionality?	A strike's military gain must outweigh its collateral civilian harm.
No mala in se?	Don't use means evil in themselves (torture, rape, poison) even in a just war.
Necessity?	Use no more force than the military goal actually requires.
Trap — which proportionality is which?	<i>Ad bellum</i> weighs the whole war's good vs harm; <i>in bello</i> weighs a single strike's gain vs its civilian harm.

The power tools

Prompt	Answer
Doctrine of Double Effect (DDE)?	You may cause civilian deaths you <i>foresee</i> but don't <i>intend</i> , if they're a side-effect of a legitimate, proportionate strike. Intending them (as aim or means) is always forbidden.
Who's linked to DDE?	Anscombe ("War and Murder") and Nagel ("War and Massacre").
DDE — the key test?	Are the deaths your aim/means (forbidden), or a foreseen side-effect of hitting a legitimate target (OK if proportionate)?
Objection to DDE?	"Foresaw but didn't intend" can be a self-serving redescription — and a death is just as bad however caused.
Moral equality of combatants?	Walzer: every soldier may kill enemy soldiers regardless of whose cause is just — they're moral equals once fighting.

Prompt	Answer
Who challenges it?	Revisionists McMahan & Rodin: a soldier on the <i>unjust</i> side is like an armed robber, so only the just side may really kill.
Liability (McMahan)?	What makes you a target isn't your uniform but your moral <i>responsibility for an unjust threat</i> . Feeds the drone/robot debates.
Mala in se?	Acts/weapons evil <i>in themselves</i> — wrong by nature, not just by effects (torture, rape, poison, arguably nuclear).
Who can call something mala in se?	A deontologist (they accept acts wrong in themselves); a pure consequentialist can't, since for them only outcomes count.
Why are non-combatants immune (3 candidates)?	Because they're <i>innocent</i> , or <i>harmless</i> , or <i>not responsible</i> for the threat. Which ground you pick is the Primoratz–Sparrow debate.

Weeks 4–5 — going to war

Prompt	Answer
Walzer's "legalist paradigm"?	War = aggression against a state's sovereignty/territory, and self-defence against that aggression justifies going to war.
Rodin's "reductivist" challenge?	National self-defence can't be grounded cleanly like individual self-defence, so the standard justification for war is shakier than it looks.
Is national self-defence like individual self-defence?	Walzer says yes (analogous); Rodin says no — a state isn't a person, so the analogy can't fully ground waging war.
Hurka's contribution?	An analysis of proportionality — which goods count in the weighing, and against what harms.
Humanitarian war?	Going to war to protect <i>foreigners</i> from their own state — human rights vs state sovereignty.
Annan / R2P?	"Sovereignty as responsibility": sovereignty is conditional on protecting your people and lapses if you slaughter them (Responsibility to Protect).
Krasner on sovereignty?	It's "organised hypocrisy" — a norm constantly invoked yet routinely broken when powerful states find it convenient.
Coady on humanitarian war?	Critiques it — sceptical that good intentions reliably produce good outcomes or escape abuse.
W5 real case?	NATO's 2011 Libya intervention — Kuperman argues it may have worsened outcomes rather than saving lives.

Weeks 6–7 — distinction & terrorism

Prompt	Answer
Primoratz on civilian immunity?	A responsibility-based account: civilians are immune because they aren't responsible for the war's threats the way combatants are.
Sparrow, "Hands up who wants to die?"	His W6 reply to Primoratz — pressing how responsibility actually grounds (or fails to ground) who may be killed.
What makes someone a legitimate target?	A threat? being responsible? wearing a uniform? Walzer says the role; McMahan says moral responsibility.
W6 real cases?	IHL/ICRC rules, civilian-targeting in Syria, and the Brereton report into alleged Australian war crimes in Afghanistan.
Define terrorism (Primoratz).	Deliberate violence against innocents to terrorise/coerce a wider group — wrong because it violates non-combatant immunity.
Held on terrorism?	Judge it by the <i>same</i> standard as war; since war kills innocents too, terrorism isn't automatically worse.
Can states be terrorists?	Yes — "state terrorism" (e.g. death squads): deliberately terrorising innocents isn't only what non-state actors do.

Week 8 — evil means (mala in se)

Prompt	Answer
W8 core clash (Nagel)?	"War and Massacre": absolutism (some things, like targeting the innocent, you must never do) vs utilitarianism (do whatever yields the best outcome).
What makes a weapon mala in se (not just destructive)?	That <i>using</i> it inherently violates distinction or dignity (e.g. poison gas) — wrong in itself, not just by its effects.
Dinstein & Forge?	Dinstein on legally prohibited weapons; Forge on whether designing certain weapons is itself wrong.

Week 9 — Nuclear weapons

Prompt	Answer
Why is nuclear philosophically central?	A strategic nuke stress-tests every in-bello principle at once — distinction (indiscriminate), proportionality (uncontainable), mala in se — plus the deterrence paradox.
Are nuclear weapons mala in se?	Arguably yes: you can't use a strategic nuke without massive civilian death, so it can't satisfy distinction or proportionality — intrinsically unusable within JWT.

Prompt	Answer
The deterrence paradox?	Can it be ethical to <i>threaten</i> to do (incinerate cities) what it would be unethical to actually <i>do</i> ? Deterrence needs a sincere threat of mass murder.
Why is it a pure Level-0 puzzle?	It turns entirely on intention vs act: even if launching is murder, is merely <i>intending/threatening</i> it also wrong?
Glover (Humanity)?	A moral history treating Hiroshima/Nagasaki as a turning point where moral restraints eroded.
Ward Wilson, "The Gordian Knot"?	Doubts the standard story — nukes may not even work as deterrents, and the Soviet invasion (not Hiroshima) may have caused Japan's surrender.
Schlosser?	"World War Three by Mistake" — the ever-present risk of catastrophic accident, an outcome-based reason against keeping them.
Radiation-vs-shrapnel probe?	"Is radiation death worse than shrapnel death?" Tests whether nuclear death is <i>especially</i> wrong or we're just overwhelmed by scale.

Week 10 — Targeted killing & drones

Prompt	Answer
Define targeted killing.	Intentional, premeditated state killing of a named individual, typically <i>outside</i> a declared armed conflict, increasingly by drone.
Why does "outside armed conflict" matter?	It blurs war (killing combatants is allowed) with law enforcement (you must arrest, not execute), so it's unclear which rules apply.
War or execution — the central debate?	Is the target a combatant (killable) or a criminal (must be arrested)? If a criminal, killing is extrajudicial execution.
Signature strike?	Killing by <i>pattern of behaviour</i> rather than confirmed identity — the most fraught form, since you may kill people you can't even name.
Byman, "Why Drones Work" (PRO)?	Drones are precise and reduce risk to your troops <i>and</i> to civilians vs the alternatives (invasions, bombing).
Boyle (ANTI)?	Strategic blowback — civilian deaths radicalise populations and breed more enemies, making campaigns counter-productive.
Coll, "The Unblinking Stare"?	A close account of the reality of the drone war in Pakistan.
Asymmetry / riskless-killing worry?	The operator faces zero danger — is risk-free killing troubling in itself? Sparrow is sceptical of asymmetric war.
Body-armour probe?	Should SAS remove body armour to make it "fair"? Probes whether risk-free killing is wrong, or force-protection is just good.

Prompt	Answer
Café cruise-missile case?	Fire at plotters in a café, killing 12 bystanders, or let them escape? Reason it aloud via proportionality + double effect, not yes/no.
Kabul 2021 case?	The August 2021 strike that killed 10 civilians incl. children — a failure of precaution-and-distinction.

Week 11 — Autonomous weapons (the examiner's field)

Prompt	Answer
Define autonomous weapon systems (AWS).	Weapons that select and engage targets <i>without meaningful human control</i> ("killer robots") — unlike drones, which still have a human pulling the trigger.
Sparrow's responsibility-gap argument?	Just conduct needs <i>someone</i> answerable for a wrongful killing, but with a truly autonomous machine no one qualifies — so using AWS to kill is illegitimate.
Why is no one responsible?	Not the programmer (couldn't predict the act), not the commander (didn't make the decision), not the machine (can't be blamed or punished).
Sparrow's "Robots and Respect" argument?	Being killed by a machine that "decides" your death fails to respect your moral status — no human agent weighs the gravity of ending your life.
Are the two arguments the same?	No — responsibility gap = <i>accountability</i> (no one answers); robots & respect = <i>dignity</i> (no human honours your status).
"Your brother" probe?	Would it matter if your brother were killed by a robot vs a human pilot? Most feel it would — Sparrow says that intuition tracks a real wrong.
Arkin (PRO AWS)?	Robots could be <i>more</i> ethical — no fear, rage, revenge — and an "ethical governor" could obey the laws of war more reliably than stressed soldiers.
Arkin's strongest punch?	If AWS would kill <i>fewer</i> civilians than humans, refusing to build them is the immoral choice.
How does Sparrow answer Arkin?	Good outcomes don't fill the accountability gap or restore dignity — fewer deaths still leaves no one answerable and the killed unrespected.
Why is Sparrow vs Arkin a Level-0 fight?	Consequentialism (Arkin: better outcomes) vs deontology (Sparrow: accountability & respect matter regardless) — in a robot costume.
Can a machine do distinction & proportionality?	Distinction needs more than object-recognition; proportionality needs <i>judgement</i> (weighing advantage vs harm) — sceptics doubt code can.

Prompt	Answer
"Meaningful human control"?	The policy demand (Campaign to Stop Killer Robots; <i>Slaughterbots</i>) to keep a human "in/on the loop" so someone stays responsible.
AWS & lowering the threshold of war?	If your soldiers face no risk, war becomes too easy to start — linking AWS back to W10 asymmetry and jus ad bellum.

Synthesis links (the differentiators)

Prompt	Answer
Nuclear deterrence × intention/foresight?	The deterrence paradox is the Level-0 intend-vs-act puzzle scaled up: is intending/threatening mass murder as wrong as doing it?
Drones × liability (McMahan)?	Liability says targetability tracks responsibility, not uniform — exactly what signature strikes get wrong (killing by behaviour, not established responsibility).
AWS × distinction (W6)?	Distinction becomes the hardest test for robots — can a machine reliably tell combatant from civilian and never deliberately hit the innocent?
Nuclear × mala in se (W8)?	Mala in se is what lets you argue nukes are intrinsically wrong, not just very destructive — they can't be used without massacring innocents.
Terrorism × distinction (W6/W7)?	Terrorism is condemned for breaking the distinction rule (deliberately killing innocents) — which is also why some call city-bombing "state terrorism."
Humanitarian war × just cause (W4/W5)?	R2P stretches "just cause" beyond self-defence to protecting foreigners — forcing the question of whether human rights can justify war.
Asymmetry × jus ad bellum (W10/W11)?	Riskless drone/robot war makes starting wars cheaper, threatening the ad-bellum demands of last resort and proportionality.
Realism × nuclear deterrence (W3/W9)?	A realist defends deterrence on survival grounds; the deontologist replies survival can't license a standing threat to murder millions.
DDE × the café/Kabul cases?	Both turn on DDE: are the civilian deaths a proportionate foreseen side-effect, or effectively intended because reckless about identity?
Pacifism × AWS (W2/W11)?	Anscombe-style critics warn AWS could erode the combatant/innocent line further — the very blurring she says pacifism wrongly encourages.

Exam technique

Prompt	Answer
The house answer format (5 beats)?	POSITION (stance) → REASON (main argument) → OBJECTION (strongest counter) → REPLY (why you still hold it) → EXAMPLE (one real case).
What does the rubric reward?	Knowledge, clarity, taking a position, and supporting it with reasons. Three of four are about FORM — always land a clear opinion + a reason.
Fallback when stuck?	Ask aloud: is this jus ad bellum or jus in bello — and which principle is in play: distinction, proportionality, or mala in se?
Most common beginner error?	Confusing jus ad bellum (going to war) with jus in bello (fighting it) — they're independent.
The six question styles?	Define & distinguish · apply a principle to a case · argue both sides · probe an intuition · connect to a real event · foundational/meta.
One-line summary of the unit?	Two theories (outcomes vs rules) → one question (is war ever OK?) → three traditions (JWT wins) → two halves → criteria → power tools → colliding in nuclear, drones, robots.
Key real cases to have ready?	US/Israel–Iran (2026), Ukraine/Bucha, Hiroshima, My Lai, Libya, the Kabul drone strike, the Brereton report.
The examiner & his field?	Robert Sparrow — W11 autonomous weapons is his own research (responsibility gap + robots & respect); he also defends robust civilian immunity (W6).
If asked your own view?	State a clear opinion in one sentence <i>and</i> give at least one reason — never fence-sit. A crisp stance with one good reason beats a balanced ramble.

Want these as an Anki/Quizlet import file (CSV)? Ask and I'll generate one — this version is built for reading and quick review.